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Switching to HTML5 in a Flash! A Tale of Two Rich Internet Platforms



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

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It seems like something out of Shakespeare. Two rich content platforms, both alike in application, divided by community and smartphone manufacturers, in fair cyberspace where we lay our scene.

Flash and HTML5 both fulfill many of the same bullet points for rich content on the web. Yet, now it seems Flash lay mortally wounded while HTML5 has quickly taken up the mantle as the new Internet standard. Surely, Flash's death has been accelerated due to incompatibility with iOS, but truth be told Flash's demise may have been a long time coming.

In no uncertain terms, [Flash runs executable applications](#). It may be packaged neatly for web distribution, but those executables [could open end users up to potential security vulnerabilities](#).



HTML5 maintains similar [support for the rich interactive content](#) that Flash delivered for many years, but attempts to seal many of the security holes that Flash allowed.

In a [2009 Symantec review of the Flash platform](#), they found that "Adobe Flash Player was subject to 23 vulnerabilities." Later Symantec expands on the dangers of what they found. "Among the vulnerabilities discovered in 2009, a vulnerability affecting both Adobe Reader and Flash Player was the second most attacked vulnerability."

Symantec offers advice on end users seeking a potential solution to the security threat posed by Flash. "Browser security features and add-ons should be employed wherever possible to disable JavaScript™, Adobe Flash Player, and other content that may present a risk to the user when visiting untrusted sites."

While HTML5 has its own set of security concerns, the new web protocol has been lauded by many in the tech world, including [networkcomputing.com's Robert Mullins](#). "HTML5 applications have more restricted access to system resources than with Flash, while HTML5 protocol updates are delivered through browser updates so they're more likely to be applied."

Adobe Flash

Developed in the Internet stone ages, 1995, FutureSplash by FutureWave Software had begun navigating the long, hard road to installing itself as an industry standard for rich content on the web.

Sites like candystand.com and Disney Online had done wonders to initially push the format into the mainstream. In an Internet where pictures were still a bit of a chore to download, Flash charged out of the gates and proved the potential of a dial-up Internet connection.

Macromedia purchased FutureSplash in 1996, and then renamed the web application Flash. It wasn't until 2005 when Adobe purchased Macromedia that Flash joined Adobe's portfolio of products.

The most important aspect of Flash that gave it such a jump on the market may have been the same aspect that brought its decline. It runs [rich Internet applications](#) that may present interactive motion graphics with a relatively small file size.

New vulnerabilities in Flash Player [continue to get exploited](#), forcing Adobe to scramble by pushing out critical security updates. And even Adobe has publicly stated they have begun "[a smooth transition to the HTML5 world](#)." They've even [halted support](#) for Flash on Google's stalwart OS, Android.

It's true that iOS outwardly refused to support Flash, which may have been the single most important factor in Flash's quick decline and HTML5's meteoric rise in use.

From the desk of Steve Jobs



As Apple goes, so goes the nation. When the makers of iOS [publicly stated their refusal](#) to include support for Flash, the [outcry amongst](#) the [Internet community](#) was [deafening](#). However, Apple had its reasoning and stood strong in opposition to the status quo.

Since we're moving toward computing without limitations, we need mobile tech to take with us where we choose. Our office is now in our tablet, our movie theaters are now in our pockets. Because of this paradigm shift that cut the cord from our desktops, certain hard truths needed to be agreed upon by mobile technology developers.

Chief among those hard truths is battery usage. Flash had never performed well on mobile devices. In his now famous open letter, Steve Jobs said, "Adobe publicly said that Flash would ship on a smartphone in early 2009, then the second half of 2009, then the first half of 2010, and now they say the second half of 2010. We think it will eventually ship, but we're glad we didn't hold our breath."

He also mentions that Flash was a solution for the PC-era. Since we've evolved beyond that, we need an evolution of the platform that presents rich media on the Internet. Among those advancements would include the touch interface that [nearly every contemporary device utilizes](#). Mr. Jobs provides advice on those looking to prep their Flash websites for a touch interface. "If developers need to rewrite their Flash websites, why not use modern technologies like HTML5, CSS and JavaScript?"

Straight from Adobe

Danny Winokur, the VP and general manager of development at Adobe, penned a telling blog post in November of 2011. He [outlined his admission that Flash was falling behind](#) in the mobile tech race and reminded Adobe's customers that the company will press forward in finding common ground with HTML5, which is in his eyes, "... the best solution for creating and deploying content in the browser across mobile platforms."

Adobe created [AIR \(Adobe Integrated Runtime\)](#) as an HTML5 wrapper for Flash. AIR circumvented Apple's iOS Flash lockout, but this still didn't address many of the persistent problems with the underlying format. [Flash's drag on the battery remained](#), and now that AIR allowed Flash applications to run outside the browser, this would also give [each program deeper access to the user's computer](#).

Winokur gave a sadly clinical declaration by noting, "[We will no longer continue to develop Flash Player in the browser to work with new mobile device configurations...](#)"

What this means for web developers still using Flash is that the tunnel is quickly closing in. More and more visitors will be greeted with a broken web-app icon when visiting Flash-driven sites.

Where do webmasters go from here?

Luckily, for those webmasters looking to make the jump to HTML5, they may only need to change their export specifications from the Adobe Flash Professional Toolkit.

Of course, that doesn't rectify the underlying design philosophies of where the web is heading, so the process of jumping to HTML5 may not be as easy for webmasters. There has been a paradigm shift in how websites are designed now.

Like Mr. Jobs said, Flash was made for the PC-era. It was made for a mouse. Simple differences like the

usage of mouse rollovers have decreased in the past few years. Since [28% of all web traffic comes from mobile and tablet devices](#), a huge piece of that pie will miss out on any information hidden behind any Flash design element that requires a cursor to come to a rest.

Information now needs to be presented much like a newspaper. Page elements must be straightforward and should include fewer fancy navigation tricks that require a mouse.

If you're a web developer who's a fan of rich media, not much will change. Find the export parameters that suit your project and export to HTML5 instead of Flash. Since Adobe is still in business and actively supporting this migration to HTML5, the process should be painless.

Flash returns from the dead!

You just can't keep a good animation platform down. And in true Shakespearian fashion, what dies rarely stays dead.

Flash has emerged as a cheap alternative to more costly animation packages for simple 2D animations. [Williams Street's Metalocalypse](#) and *Squidbillies*, and *Soup2Nuts'* Home Movies have used Flash as their animation package. *The Secret of Kells*, a 2009 Irish film, used Flash for production and snagged a nomination for Best Animated Feature at the Academy Awards.

While the future remains to be seen, Flash's emergence as an animation platform may solidify its relevance in entertainment production even though its days of Internet usage seem numbered.

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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